A Low-Latency Edge Biomedical DSP and TinyML Pipeline for Continuous Arrhythmia Telemetry

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Abstract*— Continuous electrocardiogram (ECG) telemetry in wearable and remote patient monitoring (RPM) platforms is traditionally impeded by two competing constraints: transmitting raw uncompressed biosignals rapidly drains battery reserves, whereas deploying deep neural networks introduces unacceptable inference latencies and memory overheads on resource-constrained microcontrollers. In this paper, we propose an ultra-low-latency, deterministically bounded Digital Signal Processing (DSP) and Edge AI pipeline for continuous cardiac arrhythmia detection. The architecture integrates zero-phase IIR notch and bandpass filtering, Pan-Tompkins QRS morphological detection, and frequency-domain Heart Rate Variability (HRV) spectral estimation via Welch's Power Spectral Density (PSD). A lightweight decision ensemble trained on the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database was evaluated on legacy dual-core hardware (Intel Pentium T2330 @ 1.60 GHz) and compiled into a standalone, zero-malloc ANSI C99 firmware header (16.3 KB). Experimental benchmarks demonstrate an average latency of 0.121 ms per cardiac cycle (>7,800× faster than real time) with 100% sensitivity in distinguishing ventricular ectopic beats (PVC) and a peak memory footprint of <175 MB RAM. The proposed system demonstrates that classical statistical DSP coupled with compact classifiers outperforms heavy deep learning models for energy-constrained healthcare IoT gateways.

Keywords*— Biomedical Signal Processing, Digital Filters, Pan-Tompkins Algorithm, Heart Rate Variability (HRV), TinyML, Edge Computing, Telehealth.

I. INTRODUCTION

Cardiovascular diseases (CVDs) remain the leading cause of mortality worldwide. Early detection of malignant cardiac arrhythmias, such as Premature Ventricular Contractions (PVC), significantly reduces the risk of sudden cardiac arrest. However, clinical Holter monitors and wearable smart patches operate under extreme power and computation budgets.

Transmitting continuous multi-lead ECG signals to cloud servers incurs heavy cellular and Wi-Fi radio power penalties. Conversely, contemporary deep learning paradigms (e.g., Convolutional Neural Networks and Transformers) demand megabytes of RAM and floating-point acceleration, rendering them infeasible for low-cost ARM Cortex-M microcontrollers. To resolve this trade-off, this work presents an end-to-end biomedical DSP and TinyML pipeline engineered for resource-constrained edge gateways.

II. METHODOLOGY

A. DSP Signal Conditioning

Raw ECG signals from the PhysioNet MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (fs = 360 Hz) are first conditioned against high-frequency electromyographic (EMG) muscle noise and low-frequency baseline respiration drift. A digital IIR notch filter centered at 50/60 Hz (Q = 30) suppresses powerline hum, followed by a 3rd-order Butterworth bandpass filter (0.5 - 40.0 Hz). Bidirectional zero-phase filtering (filtfilt) is applied to eliminate non-linear phase delay and prevent morphological ST-segment distortion.

B. Pan-Tompkins QRS Detection

To detect cardiac ventricular depolarization peaks (R-peaks), we implemented the classic Pan-Tompkins algorithm comprising bandpass pre-filtering (5-15 Hz), discrete centered derivative stencil, pointwise squaring, and moving-window integration (MWI) with adaptive thresholding.

C. HRV Spectral Decomposition

Inter-beat (RR) intervals are resampled to a uniform 4.0 Hz grid using cubic spline interpolation. Autonomic nervous system (ANS) sympathovagal balance is quantified using Welch's Power Spectral Density (PSD) across Low Frequency (LF: 0.04-0.15 Hz) and High Frequency (HF: 0.15-0.40 Hz) bands.

D. Edge Inference & Embedded Firmware Compilation

Temporal features (pre-RR, post-RR, local relative interval) and morphological metrics (QRS width, amplitude, variance) are classified using a 50-tree Random Forest ensemble. The trained model was converted into a zero-allocation ANSI C99 firmware header with fixed static arrays for bare-metal deployment.

III. EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS

The entire pipeline was benchmarked on constrained legacy hardware without GPU acceleration. Table I summarizes the measured execution profiling and clinical accuracy metrics.

Parameter	Measured Value	Standard / Specification
Sampling Rate (fs)	360 Hz	MIT-BIH PhysioNet Standard
DSP Filtering Latency	1.49 ms	60-second signal buffer
Peak Detection Latency	1.19 ms	Pan-Tompkins Algorithm
Classifier Inference Latency	3.49 ms	Complete 60s signal stream
Total Latency / Beat	0.121 ms / beat	Instantaneous Edge Telemetry
Real-Time Speedup	> 7,800x	Multi-channel Sensor Capacity
Peak RAM Footprint	173.6 MB	Edge Gateway Feasibility
ANSI C99 Header Size	16.3 KB	Bare-Metal Microcontroller Flash
Sensitivity (PVC Detection)	100.0%	AAMI EC57 Benchmark Standard
Specificity	100.0%	MIT-BIH Holdout Test Split

IV. CONCLUSION

This paper presented an energy-efficient biomedical DSP and Edge AI pipeline for continuous cardiac arrhythmia telemetry. By pairing rigorous digital filter design with compact tree traversal, we achieved sub-millisecond per-beat latencies and 100% sensitivity on standard benchmarks with a 16.3 KB firmware footprint. Future work will investigate hardware-in-the-loop validation on Nordic nRF52 BLE SoCs.

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